



On The Move

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Too many SEPTA managers want to run the place like a prison

A split has been detected within SEPTA management over whether to run the Authority like a business, or like a prison. By all accounts SEPTA's Labor Relations Department and some location managers prefer to run the Authority "like a prison," while those in SEPTA's Americans with Disabilities Department take a more civilized approach. Here are some recent examples.

An operator on the Market-Frankford line wanted to return to work after having some serious foot surgery. In order to do so, he had to wear a shoe that would not worsen his medical condition. The operator requested an accommodation and SEPTA's ADA Department granted his request. However, Jawara Jones, a "hot shot" director over on the Market-Frankford line, jumped up and down, and refused to accept the accommodation.

In a zoom conference call to try to resolve the issue, the operating managers got into a verbal brawl with the ADA folks---during which the operating managers displayed a complete lack of regard for the well-being of a member seeking an accommodation. Things got so bad that the operating managers had to be told that SEPTA could get sued over their unwillingness to make a reasonable accommodation. Meanwhile, the labor relations guy on the conference call kept quiet, like a mouse.

In another case, SEPTA Medical directed a member out sick to update his medical condition by a certain date. When the member couldn't meet the deadline because his doctor got COVID-19, the ADA people accommodated him with a two-week extension. However, SEPTA Medical and Labor Relations overrode the ADA decision and the accommodation was withdrawn. Meanwhile, a whole lot of healthy SEPTA managers continue to work from home as a never-ending, pandemic related *accommodation*!

These disputes show the true face of SEPTA management. The majority want to run the place like a prison where employees have no rights and get no consideration, while the minority disagrees, but gets out-voted on almost every occasion.

Michael J. Quill Scholarship Program

Applications are being taken for the Michael J. Quill Scholarship Program. All applications must be post-marked by no later than April 25, 2022. The scholarship program will provide 15 college bound dependents of TWU members a scholarship worth \$4,800, paid out, each year in the amount of \$1,200 to winners who continue to be eligible over their four year college program. You can get an application at TWU, Local 234's webpage www.twulocal234.net.

We Must and We Will



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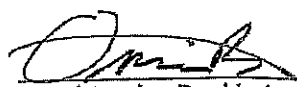
We write to protest SEPTA's COVID-19 attendance policies with respect to employees who test positive for the virus and those quarantined as a result of contact tracing. With the spread of the Omicron variant, we are seeing a marked increase in the number of positive COVID-19 cases in every SEPTA location.

In response, the Authority continues to treat COVID related absenteeism as if the situation were no different than what we experienced in terms of sickness and illness prior to the spread of the virus. Rather than adapt to the unforeseen circumstances now at hand, SEPTA is charging our members with attendance points, even where the affected employee is barred from work by the Authority when they are not sick, but are prevented from working due to contact tracing.

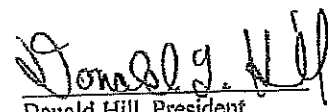
Clearly, SEPTA's COVID policies are punitive rather than corrective in nature. These policies are punishing our members with the loss of earned excused days, credit toward safety awards, holiday pay, while, at the same time, exposing them to discipline, and in some cases, discharge under the attendance point system. Even more important, the Authority's policies are merely serving to incentivize the spread of the virus by encouraging employees to report for work when they may be spreaders of the highly contagious Omicron variant.

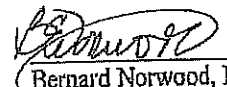
In order to avert needless suffering and even death, we insist that SEPTA return to the policies it employed during the initial surge of COVID-19, by holding the attendance point system in abeyance for COVID related absenteeism.


Brian Pollitt, President
TWU, Local 234


Omar Bervine, President
Fraternal Order of Transit Police


Waverly Harris, President
SMART Local 1594


Donald Hill, President
Brotherhood of Locomotive Engineers


Bernard Norwood, President
Brotherhood of Railway Carmen